

MANMOHAN SINGH

The Making of the Prime Minister

BY WINNING THE TRUST VOTE, THE CHOSEN PRIME MINISTER HAS ACQUIRED POLITICAL LEGITIMACY—AT LAST. CAN HE, AS A NEWLY MINTED POLITICIAN AND A POPULAR CONGRESS BRAND, SUSTAIN THE MOMENTUM?

■ **By Prabhu Chawla
and S. Prasannarajan**

Once upon a time in India, there was a prime minister who was a prime-time embodiment of un-freedom. An honourable man and a dutiful servant of the system, he was made the chief administrator by the imperial decree of the Empress Dowager of 10 Janpath, whose power was absolute. The chosen one owed his luck to the benevolence of the maximum leader, who, in a superbly choreographed melodrama of renunciation in the Central Hall of Parliament, stunned the courtiers with her “no”. In power, he was a man fettered, as the miniature Kremlin in the country’s capital exercised its ideological veto whenever he attempted reform in the marketplace. Then, with his eyes set on history but his feet still on slippery political ground, he entered into a civilian nuclear pact with the other great democracy, the United States of America. Horror, cried the commissar and a Stalinist stench enveloped Indraprastha. Kill the deal or be killed—the ultimatum was given.